

Author purpose - Study Guide

Determine what the author is trying to accomplish in the whole text or in a specific detail.

Learning goal

Identify explicit or implicit purpose and explain how selected details, examples, or organizational choices support that purpose.

What this skill really means

Author purpose is the writer's goal: what the writer wants the text or a particular part of it to do for the reader.

Broad labels such as inform, explain, persuade, describe, or entertain can be a starting point, but strong answers are more specific: explain why a policy changed, warn residents about a risk, compare two methods, or persuade readers to support a proposal.

A detail can have a local purpose that supports the larger purpose. A statistic might provide evidence; an anecdote might humanize a problem; a definition might prevent confusion.

Purpose level	Example	Better wording
whole text	inform	explain how the new pickup system works and why it was introduced
whole text	persuade	argue that the city should extend bus service later at night
specific detail	give information	provide evidence that wait times decreased
specific example	make it interesting	illustrate how the policy affects one resident in practice

How exam-style questions ask it

- What is the author's primary purpose in the passage?
- Why does the author include the statistic in paragraph 3?
- What does the author hope readers will understand after reading the notice?
- How does the example support the author's purpose?

A reliable method

1. Identify the audience and situation if the passage provides them.
2. Summarize what the text spends most of its time doing.
3. Ask what response or understanding the writer appears to want from the reader.
4. Choose a specific purpose that matches both content and tone.
5. For detail-purpose questions, connect the detail to the larger goal.

Tips and shortcuts

- Purpose is not the same as topic. "Recycling" is a topic; "explain how the new recycling schedule works" is a purpose.
- A neutral tone does not automatically mean the text only informs; a careful argument can still be persuasive.
- For specific details, finish this sentence: "The author includes this to..."

Worked examples

Example 1

A city notice lists the date food-scrap collection begins, which containers are accepted, what cannot be included, and where residents can request a bin.

1. What is the notice's primary purpose?

- A. to entertain readers with a story about waste
- B. to explain how residents should use a new collection program
- C. to argue that all trash service should end
- D. to compare food waste with plastic waste

Answer: B

The notice gives practical instructions and requirements so residents know how to participate.

Example 2

An editorial argues for later evening buses and includes the statistic that 38 percent of surveyed hospital workers finish after the current last route.

2. Why include the statistic?

- A. to provide evidence that the schedule affects a substantial group of workers
- B. to explain how to drive a bus
- C. to define the word hospital
- D. to prove every worker uses public transit

Answer: A

The statistic supports the argument by showing that many workers are affected by the current schedule.

Common traps

- An answer that states only the subject.
- A purpose that is too broad to explain the text's actual choices.
- Assuming every opinion text is emotional or every informational text is neutral.
- Choosing an effect on the reader that the passage does not appear designed to create.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, name the exact relationship between the target wording and the larger text. Point to evidence for that relationship, not just a familiar label.

Quick check

1. Turn the topic "storm preparedness" into a specific author-purpose statement.
2. Why is "to inform" often too vague as a final answer?
3. What question can you ask to find the purpose of a statistic or example?

Quick check guidance

Explain the relationship in plain language before using a technical label. If your explanation works only as a summary, ask what job, purpose, perspective, or effect is still missing.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1

If: Your answer only names the topic.

Try: Use purpose = action + target: to explain why..., to argue that..., to illustrate how..., or to challenge the idea that....

2

If: You stop at a vague label such as to inform.

Try: Ask what specific information the author chose and what the reader is meant to understand because of it.

3

If: You confuse the purpose of one statistic or example with the purpose of the whole passage.

Try: Answer at the level the question asks: word, sentence, paragraph, or entire text.

30-second reset

Before the next author purpose question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.